

12. Do young people really benefit from the use of social media?

Key Terms:

‘Young people’ and ‘the use of social media’:

Some background information:

There are new reports almost daily detailing the “extreme” usage of social media by the generation that the Kaiser Family Foundation, the health-policy think tank, notoriously named M2: children whose lives revolve around media consumption. Kaiser’s 2010 report, a study on media in the lives of young people between the ages of eight and 18, ignited a firestorm of worries about the amount young people consume, with social media being the newest and fastest-growing medium. With teens consuming more than 7-12 hours of media a day, Nielsen found in 2011 that social networks were the most visited sites on the web. And in 2014, Browser Media, Socialnomics and MacWorld discovered that nearly a quarter of all teens log on to Facebook over 10 times a day.

‘Young people’:

The focus is on the characteristics/traits that are associated with being young

‘benefit’:

The advantages gained from the use of social media

‘social media’:

Social media refers to computer-mediated tools that allow people or companies to create, share or exchange news and information, opinions and ideas, and pictures and videos in virtual communities and networks. Some of the more popular social media platforms include online forums, Facebook, Twitter, Snapchat, Instagram and YouTube.

‘really’:

A sceptical attitude - implies doubt about the benefits of social media. It implies that the benefits brought about by the use of social media are limited/insignificant or that the benefits gained are outweighed by the harm and problems it brings.

Possible Stand:

- 1) Young people do not really benefit from the use of social media i.e. the benefits are superficial/insignificant.
- 2) Social media does indeed benefit the development/growth of the young and the problems that may limit this beneficial impact of the social media are effectively mitigated by measures put in place.

Suggested Approach for Stand 1

A: Acknowledge the perception that social media benefits the young.

B: Address the scepticism (“really”) and explain why these perceived benefits experienced by the young are superficial/insignificant/limited by the risks involved in the use of social media.

Part A: Acknowledge the perception that social media benefits the young

- 1) Social media has provided the young with a range of benefits and opportunities to empower themselves in a variety of ways. It is arguable that the **ability to interact with others (which is a unique feature of social media) has provided powerful new ways for the young to create and navigate their social environments.** Young people can **maintain social connections and support networks** that otherwise would not be possible. The communities and social interactions young people form online can be invaluable in **bolstering and developing young people’s self-confidence and social skills.**

Eg : Online spaces are social spaces and social networking services such as Facebook offer similar opportunities to those offline social spaces: places for young people to be with friends or to explore alone, building independence and developing the skills they need to recognise and manage risk, to learn to judge and evaluate situations and to deal effectively with a world that can sometimes be dangerous and hostile. Such skills cannot be built in isolation and are more likely to develop if supported.

- 2) Nowadays, social media has allowed the spread of information at a rate that has never been seen before and allows one to read, analyse and share content without any prerequisites. Not only are news providers utilising social media platforms to disseminate news, the individual user is also empowered to create and share news. **With social media being a popular communication tool amongst the young, these networks are exposing them to more news and more perspectives than what they were seeking initially.** Some may argue that this increased access to information has enabled the young to become **more informed about current affairs.** This helps to **broaden their world view and enables them to make more informed decisions in life.**

E.g. According to a study from American Press Institute, virtually all millennials regularly consume a mix of hard news, lifestyle news, and practical “news you can use.” Millennials are more likely to report following politics, crime, technology, their local community, and social issues than report following popular culture and celebrities, or style and fashion. 69% of millennials get the news daily and 85% say that keeping up with the news is at least somewhat important to them.

According to research from Ipsos Mori, more than a third (34%) of social media users aged 18-24 indicated that reading something on social media would influence their vote, second only to televised debates.

Part B: Address the scepticism (“really”) and explain why these perceived benefits experienced by the young are superficial/insignificant/limited by the risks involved in the use of social media

- 1) Social media use is an integral part of the daily life of the young. While the use of social media is often associated with many benefits for the development of social skills and emotional health of the young, many are sceptical and believe that young people do not really enjoy these benefits. **Not everyone uses this platform in a positive manner to affirm and empower. Young people are particularly vulnerable to the risks inherent in the use of social media owing to their lack of emotional and psychological maturity.**

Eg : The use of social media creates opportunity for emotional distress from receiving threatening, harassing or humiliating communication from another teenager. According to a June 2012 Consumer Reports survey, 800 000 minors were harassed or cyberbullied on Facebook. Cyberbullying has been shown to cause higher levels of depression and anxiety for victims than traditional bullying and has also been connected to cases of youth suicides with teenagers known to engage in reading hurtful comments days before their suicide attempts.

- 2) **Social media websites are designed to encourage the sharing of information and the expansion of social networks. However, the young are often too open and public with personal information when online.** Most do not read privacy policies and may be unaware that their information may be used by third parties, like advertisers and insurance companies. According to Pew Research Centre, teen social media users do not express a high level of concern about third-party access to their data with only 9% saying they are “very” concerned in a survey conducted in 2013. **This creates a situation where personal information such as birth dates, current location, contact details etc can be abused by online**

predators prowling social media pages and this in turn poses a threat to the safety and well-being of the young.

Eg : Within two years of Facebook's launch, the media had begun identifying it as a possible hunting ground for paedophiles. There have been killers like Peter Chapman, in the UK, who used Facebook - and other sites - to get close to a teenage victim.

- 3) Though the young may have better access to news and information today, **they are not necessarily better informed due to the proliferation of misinformation / false news on social media.** Moreover, the young often **do not possess the wisdom and skills to critically evaluate the accuracy and trustworthiness of what they read online** which could be due to the insufficient focus on media literacy in many schools.

E.g. A research by Common Sense Media found that 31% of American teens aged 10 to 18 shared a news story online that they later found out was wrong or inaccurate and only 44% say they can tell a fake news story from a real one.

